



Map

The Ottoman Empire was a considerable force in world politics from the 14th century until the early 20th century. This map shows the borders of the Ottoman Empire at the height of its power.



various elements of government—the Diwan (supreme Court), grand vizier, and janissaries (elite army units)—all vied for power. The Sublime Porte (Ottoman Government) presented a united face to its enemies, but a century of nepotism and greed slowly ate it from within.

Although there had been a few attempts to stem the tide of misgovernment, it was only in the 1650s with Mehmet Kopprulu, grand vizier to Mehmet IV, that a systematic and enduring effort to root out corruption began. He also planned a resumption of Ottoman conquest, but died before his plans came to fruition. His brother-in-law, Kara Mustafa, continued Mehmet's expansionist policies, marching on Vienna, the capital of the mighty Habsburg Empire, in 1683. However, a combination of innovative cavalry tactics and superior artillery resulted in Mustafa's defeat.

With this defeat a steady European encroachment on Ottoman lands began, and for most of the 18th century they were at war with one or more European powers. Mahmud I brought respite to the weary empire, capturing Belgrade, and holding it under the Treaty of Belgrade of 1739. But given the ongoing corruption within government, further losses seemed inevitable.

The Blue Mosque

Built for Sultan Ahmed I between 1609–16 by master architect Sedefhar Mehmet Aga, the Sultan Ahmed mosque in Istanbul is lined with more than 20,000 handmade ceramic tiles.



Calligraphy

This is the exquisite *tughra*—a form of calligraphic monogram or seal—of Sultan Murat III and dates from 1575. Initially *tugras* were used only on official documents such as *fermans* (orders of the Sultan), but later they began to appear as a symbol of sovereignty on stamps, coins, and flags. *Tugras* even appeared on ships, mosques, and palaces.

AFTER

After 1750, the Ottoman Empire's story is one of slow, continuous decline.

LOSING GROUND

In the early 1800s, reforms were introduced to stabilize the Ottoman Empire, but its **slow dismemberment** continued. The Greeks seized independence in 1829, and the Russo-Turkish War of 1828–29 led to further losses **330–33 >>**. Bosnia-Herzegovina rebelled in 1875, and in another war with Russia in 1877–78, the Empire ceded Romania, Serbia, and Montenegro. Turkey—what was left of the Ottoman Empire—became known as “the Sick Man of Europe.”

END OF EMPIRE

Two more **Balkan Wars** (1912–13) saw the empire lose most of its remaining European territory. By the end of **World War I 372–75 >>** in 1918, the empire effectively ceased to exist, the Treaty of Sèvres of 1920 formally confirming its dissolution.



OTTOMAN COAT OF ARMS